



MANDAR DEODHAR

Keeping in mind Assembly polls, **THE CHAVAN GOVERNMENT** has decided to legalise slums that came up before 2000.



MANDAR DEODHAR

A SEA OF SLUMS (FAR LEFT); SHANTIES UNDER A SKYWALK, AND ASHOK CHAVAN (TOP)

activity for slum lords. The Congress is doing this on the eve of assembly elections for political gains, even though it has been in power for 10 years now."

Opposition parties and non-government organisations (NGOs) are concerned about the impact the Government's largesse will have on the city's infrastructure. Battling the Government against a potential catastrophe is activist Bhagwanji Rayani of Janhit Manch, an NGO which filed a public interest litigation against the transfer of development rights given to builders, which was discarded by the Bombay High Court. The court, however, stated that the Government could not extend the deadline of regularisation beyond 1995 as it would not resolve the growth of slums. Says Rayani: "The Government is not doing anything to improve infrastructure, and regularisation means putting more pressure on civic amenities. I have filed a special leave petition against the Government in the Supreme Court challenging its decision." Evidently, the state Government will not be able to issue a government resolution on

Raining Houses

Redevelopment plans in pipeline for all major slums

Dharavi, 590 acres

Houses: 57,000 families
Land Owner: State
Plan: No progress on the Rs 15,000 crore plan due to lack of transparency.

Kurla (Airport land), 272 acres

Houses: 60,000 families
Land Owner: MIAL
Plan: Slum dwellers to get tenements in different areas while HDIL gets 100 acres and higher floor space index.

Behrampada in Bandra, 7 acres

Houses: 70,000 people living in about 10,000 shanties
Land Owner: Railways and state
Plan: Free housing and also compensation to families of those killed in the fire.

On and around Jogeshwari caves, 6 acres

Houses: 500 slum colonies
Land Owner: Municipal corporation and state
Plan: High court wants removal of slums while corporators say no to demolitions.

the matter till the Supreme Court gives its ruling.

How will this initiative of the Government impact the city? Not very well, believe citizen groups and NGOs. Developers and their political patrons are rubbing their hands in glee as large tracts of public land will now be available to developers for free. Slums which have been regularised have legitimate claim on the land and can come together to develop the land by handing it to developers, who construct pucca tenements for free and gets a higher floor space index from the state for doing this. While 50 per cent of the area is used to rehabilitate slum dwellers, the remaining area is used to commercially exploit the constructed area. In addition, the developer also gets credits in the form of transfer of development rights which he can sell to other builders.

In case the apex court upholds the state Government's decision, an additional 40 lakh families will have to be accommodated in Mumbai and its suburbs and builders will be given high floor space index to construct